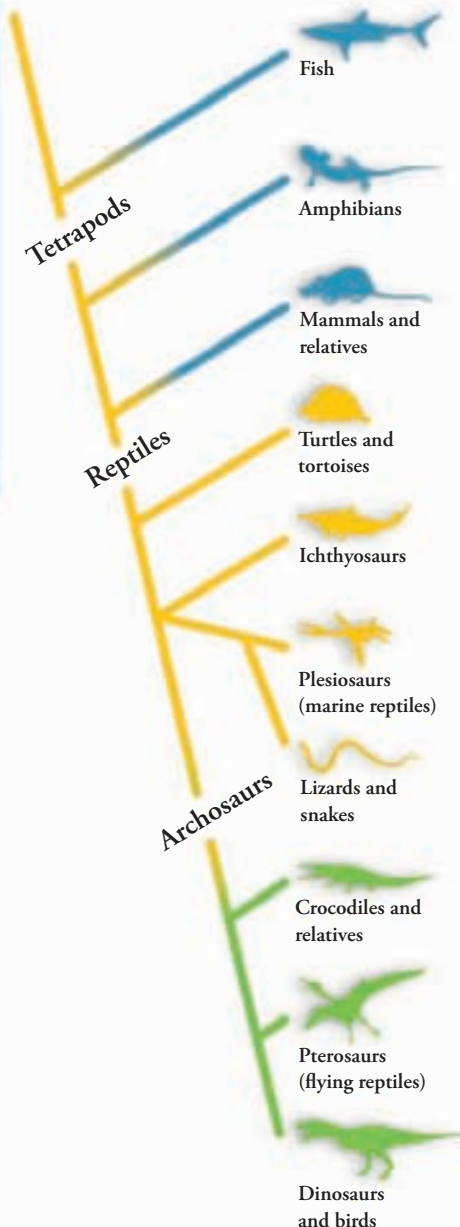


What are vertebrates?

A donkey, a crocodile, a fish, a parrot, and a frog all have one thing in common. They all have a backbone, or vertebral column, connected to a supporting bony skeleton inside their bodies. They are all vertebrates.

FAMILY TREE OF VERTEBRATES

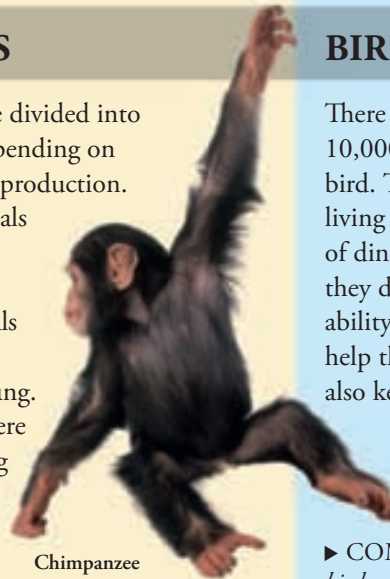
Although vertebrates are the animals we know most about, they actually make up just a tiny part of the animal kingdom. Vertebrates with limbs—tetrapods—are all descended from fish.



Vertebrates can be divided into five groups: mammals, birds, reptiles, amphibians, and fish.

MAMMALS

Mammals can be divided into three groups, depending on their means of reproduction. Placental mammals give birth to well-developed young. Marsupials give birth to undeveloped young. Monotremes (there are just five living species) lay eggs.



Chimpanzee



◀ GERBIL Rodents are a large group of mammals, characterized by large incisors, perfect for gnawing.

▼ AFRICAN ELEPHANT The largest living land mammal in the world, a male African elephant can stand 13 ft (4 m) at the shoulder.



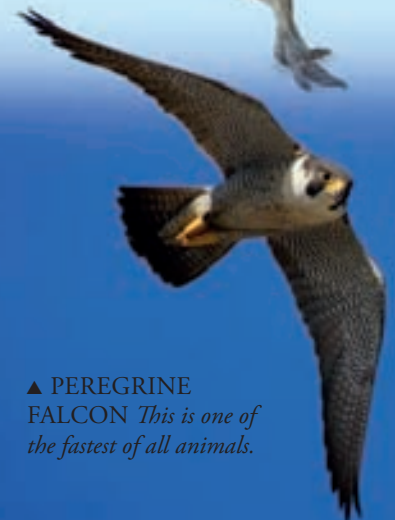
BIRDS

There are almost 10,000 species of bird. They are the living descendants of dinosaurs, but they developed the ability to fly. Feathers help them to fly, but also keep them warm.



Budgerigar

► COMMON RHEA Not all birds can fly. In fact, more than 40 species of bird, like this rhea, have lost the ability to fly.



▲ PEREGRINE FALCON This is one of the fastest of all animals.